of his feet survive the cremation—a lifetime of salt pan labour bakes them so hard that even fire cannot fully consume them. The mined salt is transported in Tata lorries and heaped into many hillocks of salt around a nearby railhead. Unlike today, salt was once a precious commodity, creating proverbial obligations to those ‘whose salt one has eaten’.



*Figure 1. Structures atop the ‘citadel’ of Dholavira*

I stay in a *bhunga*, the traditional round hut of the Kutch region, at the Dholavira Tourism Resort, an unpretentious hotel that’s a short walk from the ruins. Built by the state, it’s run by a committee of Dholavira villagers headed by the sarpanch, and its profits are invested locally. At the archaeological site in the morning, three men—a caretaker and two guides — are playing cards on a stone bench. Though tourism has risen since my last visit, I see no other tourists. The caretaker says that the site now averages three to five visitors daily in this off season, whereas thirteen years ago, in the same season, I had been the first visitor in three days. An Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) museum with an auditorium has come up as well.

The ASI, led by archaeologist R.S. Bisht, excavated Dholavira over fourteen winters, from 1989–2005. Hundreds from the Dholavira village